

MEAL PREP BORICUA

La mesa lista para la semana

A Sunday batch-cooking system built on the recipes every boricua table relies on. Cook components, not meals, and assemble all week.

Authentic recipes · Bilingual · From the Ortiz kitchen
Hecho con corazón y sofrito · sofritostudio.com

The System: Components, Not Meals

Boricua food is already built for prep — sofrito freezes, beans keep, rice reheats, and pernil tastes better the day after. Instead of cooking five meals, you cook five components on Sunday and assemble in minutes all week. The staples: a batch of sofrito, a pot of rice, a pot of habichuelas, protein, and plantains.

The Master Sofrito Batch

Homemade Sofrito — Puerto Rican Flavor Base Recipe

Sofrito · The flavor base of every Puerto Rican dish — recaó, garlic, peppers, and herbs. Make a batch in 20 minutes.

Ingredients

- 1 bunch recaó (culantro), about 15 leaves
- 1 large green bell pepper, seeded and chopped
- 1 medium onion, quartered
- 8 cloves garlic, peeled
- 1/2 cup cilantro (fresh coriander), with stems
- 2 tablespoons olive oil
- 1 teaspoon salt

Steps

1. Wash all herbs and vegetables thoroughly.
2. Add recaó, bell pepper, onion, garlic, and cilantro to a food processor.
3. Pulse until finely chopped but not pureed — you want texture.
4. Add olive oil and salt. Pulse 3-4 more times to combine.
5. Transfer to ice cube trays or jars. Freeze in portions for up to 3 months.

The Rice Base

Boricua Rice Base

La base de arroz · Simple, fluffy white rice — the canvas for everything.

Ingredients

- 2 cups long-grain rice
- 3 1/2 cups water
- 2 tbsp olive oil
- 1 tsp salt
- 1/2 tsp garlic powder (optional)

Steps

1. Rinse the rice until the water runs clear.
2. In a pot, bring water, oil, and salt to a boil. Stir in the rice and garlic powder.
3. Cover, reduce to low, and cook 18–20 minutes until the water is absorbed.
4. Turn off the heat, leave covered 5 minutes, then fluff with a fork. Cool and refrigerate in portions.

Habichuelas — The Weekly Pot

Habichuelas Guisadas — Authentic Puerto Rican Stewed Beans Recipe

Habichuelas · The everyday Puerto Rican side dish — thick, savory bean stew with calabaza that accompanies rice on virtually every plate.

Ingredients

- 2 cans (15 oz) pink beans
- 1/4 cup sofrito
- 2 tablespoons tomato paste
- 1/2 cup pumpkin (calabaza) cubed
- 1 packet sazón con culantro y achiote
- 1 teaspoon cumin
- 1 cup water
- 2 tablespoons oil
- Salt to taste

Steps

1. Heat oil in a medium pot over medium heat. Add sofrito and sauté for 3 minutes until fragrant and softened.
2. Add tomato paste and cook for 1 minute, stirring constantly to caramelize it slightly.
3. Toss in the cubed pumpkin, sazón, and cumin. Stir to coat the pumpkin in the flavor base.
4. Add the beans (with their liquid) and water. Stir well and bring to a boil.
5. Reduce heat and simmer for 20 minutes until the pumpkin is fork-tender and the broth has thickened.
6. Mash some of the pumpkin pieces against the side of the pot to thicken the stew. Taste and adjust salt before serving.

Protein: Pernil That Works All Week

Pernil Asado — Slow-Roasted Puerto Rican Pork Shoulder Recipe

Pernil · Slow-roasted pork shoulder with crispy skin and garlicky mojo criollo. The Nochebuena centerpiece.

Ingredients

- 1 bone-in pork shoulder (8-10 lbs)
- 8 cloves garlic, mashed into a paste
- 1/4 cup olive oil
- 2 tablespoons dried oregano
- 1 tablespoon black pepper
- 1 tablespoon salt
- 2 tablespoons white vinegar
- 1/4 cup sofrito

Steps

1. Score the pork skin in a crosshatch pattern with a sharp knife, cutting through the fat but not into the meat.
2. Make the mojo criollo: mash garlic with oregano, pepper, salt, vinegar, olive oil, and sofrito into a thick paste.
3. Rub the paste all over the pork, working it under the skin and into every crevice.
4. Cover tightly and refrigerate overnight (at least 8 hours) to let the marinade penetrate.
5. Roast at 375°F for about 4 hours, basting every hour, until the internal temperature reaches 185°F and the skin is crackling-crispy.
6. Let rest for 20 minutes before carving. The juices redistribute and the skin stays crisp.

Prep note: roast the pernil Sunday, then slice or shred into 3–4 portion bags. It reheats beautifully and carries rice bowls, sandwiches, and breakfast plates all week.

Plantains, Cut and Ready

Peel green plantains Sunday. Slice into toston rounds or maduros chunks, spread on a tray, and freeze solid before bagging. Fry or air-fry straight from frozen — no thawing, no sticking, dinner in ten minutes.

The 7-Day Assembly Calendar

Monday: rice + habichuelas + shredded pernil. Tuesday: tostones + leftover pernil + a squeeze of mayo-ketchup. Wednesday: arroz con pollo using the cooked rice and sofrito. Thursday: fried rice with leftover rice, egg, and any vegetables. Friday: maduros + habichuelas + a fried egg. Saturday: pastelillos or empanadillas with the prepped meat filling. Sunday: fresh — you've earned

it.

Freezer-Friendly Checklist

Sofrito: ice-cube trays, 2-tbsp cubes, up to 3 months. Rice: portioned zip bags, 1 month.

Habichuelas: airtight containers, 2 months. Cooked pernil: vacuum or tight-wrapped, 2 months.

Raw plantain rounds: 3 months. Label everything with a date — trust no memory.